



Timeline

1980

Philips and Sony agree upon the standard for the Compact Disk (CD).

1994 September

Sony/Philips announce the High-Density CD (HDCD)—the grandfather of dual-layered DVDs such as DVD-9 and DVD-18.

1995 December

The final DVD format is officially announced. Initially, the word was not an acronym. It later came to mean Digital Video Disk and Digital Versatile Disk.

1996 November

The first DVD players are released for sale in Japan.

1997 March

DVD players are available to US consumers. Also in 1997, first General DVD Forum Meeting held in Tokyo, Japan.

1998

DVD launched in Europe.

2000 July

DVD audio players launched in the USA.

2000 November

First DVD-audio disks in the USA.

2001

DVD-video recorders launched in Europe.

2002

DVDs officially make their appearance in India.

can add episodes of your favourite TV serial to a DVD+RW, and play it instantly on a DVD player. However, DVD-RWs needs finalisation before playing.

Another factor is the Mount Rainier support, the *de facto* standard with all future releases of Windows. It lets you write directly to a DVD+RW sans any special software. Not so with the DVD-Rs and DVD-RWs since this was not specified in their format.

Compatibility

DVD-R, DVD-RW, DVD+R and DVD+RW media are compatible with 85 per cent of the available standalone DVD players. As for DVD-RAM disks, they were not designed for, and are not compatible with, any of the available DVD players. Only specialised drives, such as, the Iomega SuperDrive read them.

The Dual-layer Format

All available DVD media are limited to single-layered, single-sided mode (DVD-5) and hold up to 4.7 GB of data. Some manufacturers sell dual-

sided, single-layered media (DVD-10), but these are a fast disappearing specie since the same amount of data fits onto single-sided, dual-layered DVD-9 disks. This also provides less clutter since you are effectively stuffing two disks worth of data on a single disk.

Philips and Mitsubishi Kagaku Media developed the first DVD+R and DVD+RW dual-layered media, meant for general users. Not to be left behind, Pioneer released a dual-layer format of the DVD-R.

Worldwide, dual-layered media is scarce and was not available in India at the time of going to press. Also, as of now, only dual-layered DVD+Rs and DVD+RWs are available. For the purists who would rather opt for a dual-format, dual-layered DVD-Writer, there still may be some time to go before they actually get hold of one.

Two media layers are separated from each other on one single side of the disk. While writing, the first layer is written with the same speed as that used on a single-layered disk. As the laser switches to the second layer, the speed decreases and the data is written at a much slower speed.

For example, the DVD-Writer may slow down from 4X to 2.4X. The point at which this switch occurs is a known issue for the current crops of DVD-ROM drives available in the market.

When we conducted DVD-ROM drive tests, the older Creative 12X PC DVD drives did not recognise the dual-layered disk sample, though it did read single-layered disks. The new Samsung SD-616F 16X DVD-ROM drive read the dual-layered disk without any problems and so did the Lite-On LDW-811S and 812S and the LDW-401 DVD+RW drive. Hence, be warned that compatibility can be an issue with older DVD-ROM drives.

Buying Guide

Portability

External as well as internal DVD-writer drives are available. If your job involves taking backups from PCs scattered across different locations, an external drive would be ideal. All you need to do is connect it to the PC, and backups can be done instantly. While opting for an external drive, make sure that it supports both USB 2.0 and Firewire for high-speed data transfers.

Speed

A 4X dual-format DVD-writer costs less than an 8X dual-format DVD-writer. The latest DVD-writers have speeds of around 12X. Writing 4.7 GB of data at a speed of 4X takes about 15 minutes,



DVD+R: A Cross-section View

